

GET A GRIP ON YOUR FINANCIAL LIFE

Figuring Out Where You Are and Where You Want to Go

YOU MAY THINK that with all the chaos in the economy, it's impossible to get your own money in order. Well, the good news is that there's a lot you can do—very easily—to take charge of your financial life.

You don't have to be that guy or gal who spends hours sifting through receipts or color-coding tax folders. Life's way too short, but (you knew there'd be a *but*) the longer you wait, the harder it is to get organized. Yes, it's tempting to put off planning for the future until you start making more money, or the economy soars. But remember, although your paycheck will increase as you get older (we hope), your financial commitments will too. So get started today. This chapter will help you get organized.



PUTTING A PRICE TAG ON YOUR GOALS

You probably have one or two specific financial dreams that you'd love to realize within the next few years. You may want to buy a car. You may long to get rid of your credit card debt. You may fantasize about owning a house.